

KDE Plasma Active is a project by the KDE community that aims to bring their software to tablets and they have taken a very unique approach in doing so.

Gnome and Unity decided to make a single UI that is somewhat touch friendly while still being passable on desktops. KDE developers on the other hand decided that each form factor needs its own optimised



Plasma Active welcome screen

UI. As such they have a traditional desktop-like UI, a netbook UI for smaller screen devices, and Plasma Active for tablet devices – they may add a mobile version in the future as well.

Plasma Active also has a unique concept called activities, that changes the way you work with tablets. Activities let you group together related files / data and applications and settings. So if you switch to your “Work” activity, you’d have work-related items on your desktop, work-related bookmarks and contacts, and also work related applications and shortcuts.

Chrome OS

Chrome OS hasn’t died yet? We kid! The fact of the matter is that Chrome OS, and in turn Google’s Chromebooks have a very compelling use case. When Chrome OS and Chromebooks were announced a common reaction was, “An OS / computer that can only be used to browse the web? Meh!”

The idea isn’t as absurd as it might seem to some people. Putting it in perspective, gaming consoles (such as the XBOX 360/PS3) are computers designed specifically for games. Thus, just as a small percentage of people are willing to buy a device just to game, perhaps another small percentage would buy a device just to surf. If even 1 per cent of a billion people online would be willing to buy such a device, that’s sales of 10 million devices!

However, consoles are viable because the maker takes a cut from video game developers, and this keeps them afford-

able. Google already dominates the internet advertisement space. Also, consoles need amazing hardware specifications, while devices meant solely for web browsing can be low-powered, longer battery-life devices – and these are cheaper. All Chromebooks need to do is make Google a net profit with ads. For us consumers, it’s a device that starts quickly, runs a wide variety of applications, and with the addition of Native Client, can even run games and heavy video / audio editing apps.

Linux on Desktops

Every year is the year of the Linux desktop; that is until every December 31st. The number of Linux users still hovers below 5 per cent. People stick to Windows for their favourite applications, and makers of those favourite applications don’t port for Linux citing a lack of user base.

The Achilles heel of Linux, gaming, had a good year in 2012, and 2013 is set to be even better. 2012 saw a number of Humble Bundles that resulted in numerous games becoming available for Linux, and it would be remiss of us to not mention Humble Indie Bundle V that brought critically acclaimed games such as Bastion, Limbo and Psychonauts to Linux. Even the Humble THQ Bundle despite controversy for using Steam and being Window-only, compelled the THQ management to consider Linux support for future titles. Desura, a game store that sells games for Windows, Linux and Mac OSX, expanded from its Linux launch selection of around 60 titles to 200. The year also saw the release of the Unity 4.0 game engine, the first version to support Linux. Dozens of KickStarters launched, and many promised Linux support from the get-go.

This year also saw the announcement of and release of Steam for Linux. It has gone through a closed beta phase and is now widely available. Steam for Linux will have dozens of games that already support Linux, and most Valve titles are also expected to be available on the platform.

Another point of note with Steam and Linux is that Valve is working on a PC-based console, and in all likelihood that console too will run Linux.

Steam also announced support for software titles this year which could also be released for Linux. Dell introduced a powerful Linux-based laptop for developers that actually showcased software, rather than just drivers and a re-skin. The first profes-



Steam running on Ubuntu Linux

sional-grade, award-winning, non-linear video editor “Lightworks” might finally be released for Linux in 2013. 2013 the year of the Linux desktop? Don’t hold your breath, but anything’s possible.

Ponies

Tizen! What can we say about this OS that is steeped in so much confusion. In short, Nokia makes Maemo Linux for mobile, Intel makes Moblin Linux for mobile, they have a bouncing baby called MeeGo. Nokia has an affair with Microsoft with little care for its bundle of joy. Meanwhile Intel starts courting Samsung and decides to abandon its child for a new one instead. That child is Tizen, and sadly it has a confused childhood (not to mention daddy issues). Samsung plans to merge its own bada OS with Tizen and adopt Tizen for some of its phones – in addition to Android and Windows Phone. Samsung is a powerful force in the mobile world, but Tizen 1.0 has come and gone without a commercial device running it and now Tizen 2.0 nears...

Two other dead projects have been on the path to resuscitation, webOS and MeeGo. While HP has open sourced webOS with no clear plans for a future product, exactly such a product might come from an external company called Phoenix International Communications. Likewise Jolla is set to revive MeeGo on its own set of devices, coming out in 2013.

The biggest surprise we hope would be if people actually realised that competition is good for all, and that there is no “winning” OS. In fact it would be terrible for one OS to win, as monopoly hurts the consumer. With a number of small companies trying to enter the smartphone market, there could be nothing better than said small companies offering a wide variety of devices, keeping the goliaths on their toes, and making sure we consumers get what we pay our hard earned money for. ■